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Emerging trend: PC rejuvenation

Laptops, smartphones and tablets may be the talk of the town, but the good old PC hasn't gone away just yet. In fact, desktop PC sales are increasing, even if their pie has shrunk in size. And the trend is expected to continue, according to **Ravi Gupta** from Intel's Public Sector and Enterprise Solution Group. He tells us why PCs are back in fashion. Excerpts from our interview:

◀ **Ravi Gupta**, Intel's Public Sector and Enterprise Solution Group

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Q Consumer desktop sales are down in the dumps. But businesses still invest in PCs, and for Q2 2014, IDC reported PC sales to be rising in India. What's this all about?

Ravi: What we've witnessed over the past couple of years, especially with the explosion of tablets and smartphones, is that it vastly overshadowed the growth of PCs. It wasn't that desktops weren't growing, but that every article, review and the public's imagination at large was captured by smart handheld devices. And that led to this perception that desktops weren't growing. If you look at last year alone, we shipped close to 4.7 million units in India, a majority of which were actually commercial grade desktops. We're seeing desktops being rejuvenated for both consumption and compute experiences on the consumer as well as business side of the PC market.

Q The desktop has transformed in terms of form factors. How's that affecting its chances of a comeback?

Ravi: You see the primary innovations on the PC side are driven purely by usage models which are changing on the consumer side. An unmistakable trend is emerging — that desktops should have show-off value and be easy to use, along

with the added bonus of touch interface, enabling and fulfilling the larger home network, home entertainment function.

If you look at buyers of PC in India, as far as businesses are concerned, they need frequent innovation that makes PC usage exciting, productive and energy-efficient. And the evolution of PCs to Mini-PCs, AIOs, split-screen devices, etc., have all managed to do that. In the last year alone, demand for AIOs and other small form factor PCs with always-on capability, low energy footprint, without compromising on good performance has gone up. So essentially a laptop-grade product morphed into a desktop-like device, and that's where AIOs and Mini-PCs have gained popularity.

Q When it comes to PC buying decisions, do customers prefer powerful PCs over power-saving PCs? Functional vs. desirable, what's in demand?

Ravi: So today's PC buyers are looking at three essential things — bare minimum performance to get work done (productivity), security (since most of their data resides in the cloud), and manageability of devices. The three pillars — productivity, security and manageability — together dictate and influence 70 per cent of buying decisions. The rest 30 per cent is governed by things like power-efficiency, looks and design, etc.

Q Where does the good old PC go from here? Will the desktop ever be replaced in the foreseeable future?

Ravi: From strength to strength! The forecast of desktop PC sales in 2015 is a little above the total number achieved for 2014, so that's great. We expect the figure to be somewhere close to 4.8 million for this year, as far as desktop sales is concerned. We're already at the cusp where the mobility success story is losing steam, and coupled with the incremental desktop buyers both at home and offices, these two trends will drive desktop sales to rise in the coming year. Also, the government's financial inclusion initiative presents a tremendous opportunity for solution providers to deploy desktop PCs to innovate and deliver new automation and user experience models.

As to whether desktops will ever be replaced — a question I've been asking to multiple vendors myself — let me answer it this way. What we used to call a desktop earlier, we now refer to as an AIO, a Mini-PC, Tiny PC, Thumb PC, Portables, etc. We may not see the traditional tall tower sitting around on our desks in the future, but certainly some sort of discrete computing where the user has the option to intervene, to issue commands, to consume and create content, will continue to exist as long as digital systems are alive and ticking. **Q**